

◀ THE TRIASSIC saw the planet's first dinosaurs, all fairly small, like this *Coelophysis*. They lived in a hot, largely barren world.



Triassic life

251–200 million years ago

In the Triassic period, Earth's land formed a single continent called Pangaea. The coast and river valleys were green, but much of the interior was desert. There were no flowering plants; instead, tough-leaved plants such as cycads (a palmlike tree), ginkgos, horsetails, and conifers flourished (all of which are still with us). Early dinosaurs included *Herrerasaurus*, *Plateosaurus*, *Chindesaurus*, *Coelophysis*, and *Eoraptor*.

Cycad



▲ TRIASSIC EARTH

Pangaea began to break up during the Triassic, with the Tethys Sea pushing between its two halves.



Brachiosaurus

Stegosaurus

Jurassic life

200–145 million years ago

Pangaea broke into two continents around 200 million years ago, with oceans spreading over what had been land to create enormous shallow seas. The Jurassic saw the emergence of giant, plant-eating sauropods (such as *Brachiosaurus* and *Diplodocus*) and large predators (such as *Allosaurus*).

Lush forests spread across the land and the deserts shrank. Common plants included conifers, monkey puzzle trees, and ferns.

Fern



▲ JURASSIC EARTH

Pangaea split into Laurasia in the north and Gondwana in the south, with shallow seas between.

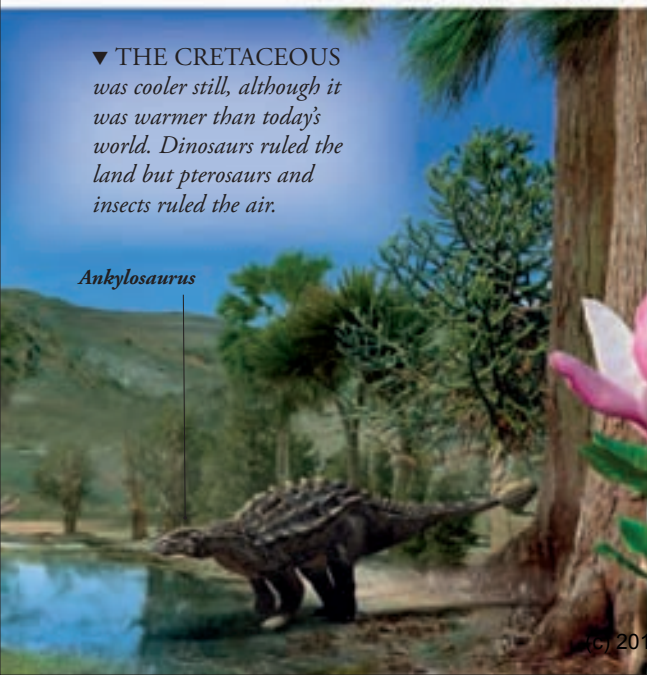
▼ THE CRETACEOUS was cooler still, although it was warmer than today's world. Dinosaurs ruled the land but pterosaurs and insects ruled the air.

Cretaceous life

145–65 million years ago

The continents continued to break up during the Cretaceous. As a result, dinosaurs on different continents evolved in different ways, giving rise to many new species. *Tyrannosaurus* emerged, as did *Triceratops* and *Iguanodon*. Flowering plants appeared; early species included magnolias and passion flowers. Dense forests contained trees we know today, such as oak, maple, walnut, and beech.

Magnolia



Ankylosaurus



▲ CRETACEOUS EARTH

The continents began to resemble those we recognize today during the Cretaceous period.